

THE MONK WHO DROVE HIS CAMPAIGN
The victorious Yogi Adityanath acknowledges the adulation of the crowd in Lucknow

in 2017, but a clear majority nevertheless. The party also managed to increase its vote share—from 39.7 per cent in 2017 to 41.3 per cent this election. Together with the allies, the tally stood at 273, from 326 in 2017.

The overwhelmed Adityanath, drenched in the colours of a Holi come one week early, stood visibly humbled by the mandate. This was his win, a vote for his chief ministership. In 2017, that chief ministership had been bestowed on him; in 2022, he had earned it. The politics of caste and religion, he said while addressing party workers at the state BJP headquarters, had been well and truly buried, people had voted for development, nationalism and good governance. The bulldozer, an unflattering metaphor in any other circumstance, became the symbol of firm resolve in Yogi Adityanath's case, conveying the impression of corruption being razed to the ground.

That trend was reflected in the India Today-Axis My India exit poll: 22 per cent of the respondents said they voted for development, 8 per cent on law and order and 6 per cent for the free ration.

There was no dearth of factors that were thought capable of marring saffron chances: fears that the Jats had been alienated, thanks to the contentious farm laws that the central government first passed in September 2020 and then judiciously revoked in November 2021, or price rise, unemployment, the Samajwadi Party's Akhilesh Yadav drawing huge crowds at rallies, anti-incumbency against sitting MLAs, stray cattle. As it happened, all these turned out to be unfounded. The BJP cornered 47 per